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MUS/COM 114-D1

27th March 2026

Kathak Through the Lens of Gender Dynamics

Kathak is one of the main classical dances of South Asia, whose origins date back to narration, rhythm and expressive art. Beyond aesthetics, Kathak also reflects gender dynamics shaped by history and society. Gender roles in Kathak are socially constructed because, according to Pallabi Chakravorty, “women have been the primary bearers of religious symbols and cultural traditions in colonial and postcolonial India” (Chakravorty, 2008). This essay explores the roles of male and female dancers, the challenges they have faced, and how social expectations affect their training, opportunities and performances, while engaging with debates surrounding patriarchy and gender fluidity.

Historically, Kathak was performed by male storytellers known as Kathakars, demonstrating early male dominance within the form (Dhaara Magazine, 2023). However, during the Mughal era, female performers, especially Tawaifs, became central to the form. These women were highly skilled artists, but operated within a patriarchal system. Although they played a vital role in the development of Kathak, they were socially marginalised. As Manjari Chaturvedi points out, their contributions have often been misrepresented and reduced to stereotypes rather than recognized as artistic achievements (Chaturvedi, 2025). The cinematic figure of *Umrao Jaan* further reflects this tension by portraying a courtesan as both an artist and a socially marginal figure.

The impact of colonial rule further intensified these challenges. By labelling performers as “nautch girls”, colonial authorities erased the distinction between artists and sex workers (Dhaara Magazine, 2023). This stigma continues to affect female dancers’ opportunities and public perception. Chakravorty highlights that “this idealized identity of a female dancer... is entirely different from... everyday lives” (Chakravorty, 2008), pointing out the gap between performance and reality. Women are expected to embody grace on stage but face restrictions offstage. Many struggle to maintain rigorous training due to domestic responsibilities and societal expectations surrounding marriage and family. One dancer recalls being mocked, “there she goes, the bai”, demonstrating how moral judgments and class-based stigma constrained women’s visibility and mobility (Chakravorty, 2008). These societal expectations affected women’s ability to pursue consistent training and limited their professional opportunities, while also shaping performances that emphasized modesty and controlled femininity.

Women have been using Kathak as a locus of agency and change despite these limitations. Chakravorty also shows that a few middle and lower-middle-class backgrounds were able to achieve social mobility with the help of dance, be it as instructors or professional dancers. An example of this is evident in the case of Dr Maya Rao, who, despite the social stigma attached, devoted her life to Kathak under a Master called Shambhu Maharaj. On the same note, dancers like Sitara Devi defied the customs of the time and increased the presence of women in dance. These instances demonstrate that although there were structural hindrances against women, they actively negotiated and transformed their positions within Kathak.

In contrast, male dancers historically held authority within Kathak’s institutional structures. The guru-shishya system and gharans were dominated by male lineages such as Kalka and his sons, Achchan Maharaj, Lachchu Maharaj and Shambhu Maharaj, who played an

important role in shaping the traditions. As Chakravorty notes, “the identity... of a dancer is derived from... patriarchal male lineages... women... are never given the same status” (Chakravorty, 2008), highlighting how training systems, recognition and authority have historically privileged men, limiting women’s access to leadership roles within the art form.

However, male dancers are no exception because they struggle with social constructs of masculinity. Dance is considered feminine, even in contemporary contexts, despite men holding institutional power. When one of the dancers, Asfandiyar Khattak, questions, “Is a man only made for breaking stones?” (Khattak, 2023), that raises the issue of limiting gender standards, which do not allow men to express themselves. Male dancers may face ridicule, family resistance and lack of acceptance, especially in expressive performances. Other actors observe that these performances are commonly dismissed as a “farce” (Mir, 2017), indicating how masculinity is policed within cultural spaces. These issues show that men are not only structurally powerful but they are also limited by social demands at the identity and performance levels.

Simultaneously, Kathak offers possibilities for challenging rigid gender roles. Through the abhinaya, dancers portray both female and male characters, allowing movement across identities within a single performance (Dhaara Magazine, 2023). The co-existence of masculine and feminine principles is supported by philosophical ideas such as advaita and representations like Ardhanarishwara (Vaidyanathan, 2024). This implies that gender in Kathak is not fixed but performed (Dhaara Magazine, 2023), enabling dancers to reinterpret identity within established traditions.

Scholarly debates remain divided on whether Kathak challenges or reinforces gender norms. Some argue that its performative nature allows dancers to transcend rigid identities, while others emphasize that the form continues to operate within patriarchal frameworks, namely with

the help of male-dominated institutions (Dhaara Magazine, 2023). This tension highlights that Kathak both reflects and questions societal values.

In conclusion, Kathak can be understood as a dynamic and evolving space where identity is continuously negotiated. Female dancers face constraints related to respectability and domesticity, whereas male dancers confront stigma surrounding masculinity. Nevertheless, Kathak offers chances of opposition and redefinition as well. As Chakravorty notes, “women are emerging as agents of their own history” (Chakravorty, 2008) and male dancers are similarly redefining masculinity through performance, Kathak therefore exists between tradition and change, making it a significant space for examining and reimagining gender identity.

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